AN ORIGINAL COUNTRY-HOUSE MYSTERY

THE LAST BELL OF ASHCOMBE HOUSE

ILLUSTRATED STORY BOOK

Read the entire story before opening the evidence packets. The ending is kept in a separate guide.



1-6 INVESTIGATORS | 90-120 MINUTES | AGES 14+

An autumn storm. Six suspects. One unfinished announcement.

READER BRIEFING

A witness without an interest

England, 17 October 1934. You are an independent historical researcher invited to Ashcombe House. You are the investigating viewpoint, not one of the suspects. In group play, everyone shares that role.

Edmund Ashcombe has gathered six people for a private announcement. Before he can deliver it, he is found dead. A storm delays the police, and the household must preserve the evidence until help arrives.

This book contains the complete player-facing narrative. It intentionally ends before the accusation. The case is completed through the separate evidence and puzzle PDFs; the Solution Guide is for the end of play only.

READING ORDER

Story > Character Cards > Evidence E01-E08 and E10-E12 > Puzzle Sheets > sealed E09 > written accusation > Solution Guide.



CHAPTER 01

The Invitation

The invitation arrived on heavy cream paper, its edges still carrying the faint smell of the cedar drawer in which it had been kept. Edmund Ashcombe requested your presence at his country house on Wednesday, 17 October 1934. There would be supper at eight, a private exhibition of the family collection, and an announcement at half past nine.

At the bottom, beneath the formal signature, he had added a sentence in a less steady hand: 'I would value a witness who has no interest in the outcome.' You knew him only through a small commission to catalogue local historical records. The request was unusual enough to accept.

Ashcombe House stood beyond a flooded lane, its long windows shining through the rain. In the entrance hall, a brass handbell rested on a side table. Its handle was shaped like a swallow, and its base carried a crescent-shaped chip. Martha Reed, the housekeeper, moved it away from the edge as she took your coat.

'Mr Ashcombe uses it when the electric call system fails,' she said. 'Which, in this weather, it usually does.' Somewhere upstairs a door closed. A woman laughed once, sharply, and then the house returned to the sound of rain.

CHAPTER 02

Six Places at Supper

Edmund introduced the guests with the careful courtesy of a man arranging objects in a display case. His niece Nora wore an emerald dress and kept turning a pearl earring between finger and thumb. Dr Felix Mercer spoke warmly, although his attention repeatedly wandered towards his host.

Gideon Pike, a dealer in manuscripts and decorative arts, greeted the house as if he might one day sell it. Arthur Bell, the groundskeeper, had been invited inside because the flooded bridge had trapped him on the estate. He sat at the end of the table, uncomfortable in a borrowed tie.

Celia Ward, the family archivist, arrived last from the west wing. Her plum jacket had pale violet cuffs, each edged with a distinctive double row of stitching. You noticed the right cuff when she steadied a wineglass. It had a little triangular repair near the seam.

Martha supervised supper rather than joining it. Edmund insisted that she stay within hearing for the announcement. 'It concerns the house,' he told her. 'Everyone who has kept it alive should hear it.'

Nobody asked what he meant. That was the first thing about the evening that seemed rehearsed: six people, each waiting for someone else to speak.

CHAPTER 03

A House of Borrowed Things

The collection occupied three rooms: a portrait gallery, a map room, and the library. Edmund showed you a seventeenth-century atlas under glass, a little silver compass, and a cabinet of letters written by people whose names had outlived their fortunes.

'The difficulty with an inheritance,' he said, 'is deciding whether you own it, or merely hold it for the next person.' Gideon smiled politely. Nora did not.

In the map room you saw a small framed photograph of an astronomical drawing. Celia explained that the original had gone away for conservation. Her answer was quick and exact; she named a workshop in York without pausing.

Edmund touched the edge of the frame. 'Yes,' he said. 'Conservation.' He let the word hang there until Celia turned towards another cabinet.

On a nearby table lay a printed exhibition list. Several descriptions used the same peculiar capital R: one leg sat noticeably higher than the other. Celia's office typewriter stood in the adjoining archive. A luggage label tied to its case read 'SERVICE REQUIRED', though it looked well used.

These were ordinary details in an old house. Only afterwards would you begin separating what merely belonged to the room from what someone had carefully arranged for you to see.

CHAPTER 04

The Photograph

At five minutes past nine, Nora gathered everyone beneath the gallery clock for a photograph. She wanted a record, she said, before the family lost any more furniture. Edmund allowed the remark to pass.

The camera belonged to the house: a compact plate camera on a tripod, prepared earlier by Arthur. He operated the shutter and then set the holder aside for later development. The view included Nora, Edmund, Celia and Gideon; Felix had stepped to the telephone alcove. Martha appeared at the edge carrying an empty tray.

You stood beside Arthur and watched the flash brighten the pale cuffs of Celia's jacket. The right one lay flat and complete. Its triangular repair was clearly visible when she lifted her hand to shade her eyes after the exposure.

The time mattered because Nora asked you to read the gallery clock before Arthur reset it for a second attempt. 'Nine-oh-five,' you said. The second photograph was never taken.

Edmund beckoned Celia aside. You heard only the end of their conversation: 'Bring the folio. The blue one. We shall settle the dates before the others come in.' Celia nodded. Her face looked composed, but she had stopped looking at the camera.

CHAPTER 05

The Blue Folio

Edmund took you into the library and asked whether you could remain until the announcement. On his desk lay a blue document folio sealed with wax, a small dispatch box, and an empty envelope addressed to his solicitor.

'I have checked one account against another,' he said. 'That is often enough. People expect you to examine the impressive document and overlook the ordinary receipt.' He slid the envelope beneath a blotter before you could read more.

You asked whether he expected trouble. He looked at the library door, then towards the narrower service door beside the bookshelves. Both opened normally. Neither had a special lock or a hidden passage beyond it.

'I expect explanations,' he replied. 'There is a difference.'

Before you left, Edmund asked Martha to bring the swallow-handled bell from the hall. The electrical call button had failed again. Martha set the bell on the desk at 9:08, beside the blue folio, while you watched from the doorway.

The scene would later be remembered as an arrangement of important objects. At the time it was only a man preparing to do difficult business in private, with a bell to summon help if the house became too quiet.

CHAPTER 06

The Key Book

The archive key hung behind Martha's pantry door. It opened the locked document cupboard in the library, not the library itself. Martha kept a ruled book beside it: anyone taking the key was expected to write their name and the time.

At 9:10, while you returned a borrowed umbrella to the hall, Celia came through the pantry passage. She wrote in the book and took the key. Arthur, who was drying his boots nearby, asked whether she needed a lamp.

'Only the inventory folder,' she said. 'I shall be back in the archive almost at once.'

Martha had gone to the kitchen. The cook needed help with a leaking window, and the corridor smelled of wet plaster. Arthur followed her with a bucket. You returned to the gallery to speak with Nora about the photograph.

Later, people would treat the entry in the book as if it were a record of Celia entering and leaving the library. It was not. It recorded the borrowing of a key, and nothing more. No one saw her return it until 9:22.

That distinction was small enough to disappear inside a confident statement. It was also the first distinction your investigation would need to recover.

CHAPTER 07

A Letter in the Corridor

Nora asked whether Edmund had mentioned her. When you said no, she looked relieved and disappointed at once. A folded letter protruded from her evening bag. She pushed it deeper inside before explaining that she had been trying to persuade her uncle to help a friend.

Gideon crossed the gallery carrying a catalogue. He paused beside Nora and said, 'Some difficulties are temporary. Your uncle knows that.' She replied that he knew a great many things and understood very few of them.

At 9:12, Martha appeared in the doorway and asked Nora to help move a small box of family linen away from the leaking roof above the linen room. Nora went with her. You saw the two women disappear up the east stair.

Felix returned from the telephone alcove, annoyed that the storm had interrupted a call. The operator had connected him at 9:09. He said he would try again and went back along the hall.

There was still no sense of danger. The house was busy with minor emergencies: rain in a cupboard, a broken call button, a conversation postponed. Each small inconvenience gave someone a reason to be elsewhere.

CHAPTER 08

A Single Bell

At 9:14, a bell sounded from the direction of the library. One clear note travelled into the gallery and was cut short by a heavier noise. You looked up from the exhibition list.

Gideon stood beside the open map-room door. 'Dropped something,' he said. He did not move towards the library. Neither did you. Edmund had asked for privacy, and a bell in a house full of servants did not yet suggest an emergency.

Near the far end of the service corridor, Arthur heard the same note while carrying a bucket from the kitchen. He also heard the service door strike its frame a moment later. He saw nobody emerge. The bend in the passage hid the library doorway from where he stood.

At the telephone alcove, Felix heard little beyond the operator repeating his number. Upstairs, Nora and Martha were lifting the linen box together. They would remember the noise only after being asked about it.

You looked at the gallery clock because the interruption had broken your conversation. Its minute hand stood on fourteen. It was not a stopped clock, not a clock secretly altered. The evening's most important sound had occurred in plain time, in a house where almost nobody thought to answer it.

CHAPTER 09

The Second Sight of Celia

At 9:20, you passed the archive doorway on your way to the lavatory. Celia sat at her desk, sorting index cards beneath a green-shaded lamp. She looked up and asked whether Edmund had begun his announcement.

'Not yet,' you said. 'It is only twenty past.'

She drew her right hand beneath the desk. Before she did, you noticed a jagged gap in the lower edge of the pale cuff. A narrow triangular section was missing beside the old repair. You assumed she had caught it on a cabinet handle.

The office smelled faintly of hot metal from the lamp and damp wool from her jacket. An open drawer held blue sealing wax, spare ribbon and folders. These were the tools of her work, and none of them was suspicious by itself.

She said she had been there since ten past nine. Her tone made it sound like an idle fact, offered only to explain why she had lost track of the evening.

At 9:22, Martha saw her return the archive key. Celia entered the time in the book. The neat interval on the page would later appear to support a tidy errand. You had already seen the one detail that did not fit neatly inside it.

CHAPTER 10

The Announcement That Did Not Come

At half past nine, everyone drifted towards the gallery. Gideon straightened his tie. Nora had dust on one shoulder from the linen box. Arthur stood near the staircase, reluctant to tread further onto the carpet.

Edmund did not appear. Martha waited two minutes, then knocked on the library door. There was no answer. She opened it, said his name, and stopped.

He lay beside the desk, beyond the pool of light from the reading lamp. The handbell rested on the carpet nearby. Its swallow handle pointed towards the service door. The blue folio was still on the desk, but its wax seal had been broken.

Felix went forward, then asked everyone else to remain back. After a short examination he said Edmund was dead and that the injury was consistent with a heavy blow. He would not pretend to identify the exact minute of death from what he could see.

Martha called the village constable. The line worked long enough to carry the message before failing again. Floodwater had made the lane unsafe; help would come as soon as the bridge could be crossed.

Until then, six people waited beneath the gallery clock, while the seventh would never make the announcement for which they had all assembled.

CHAPTER 11

Keeping the Room

You asked everyone to step away from the library entrance. Nobody was to touch the bell, the desk or Edmund's clothing. Martha brought clean paper so you could make a record of what was visible without moving anything.

The main door and service door were both unlocked. The windows were fastened from inside, but this was not a room that required an intruder to climb through a window. Anyone already in the house could have entered by either door.

A scrap of pale violet cloth was caught in Edmund's left hand. From the doorway you could see part of a double line of stitching. You recorded it and covered the hand loosely with clean paper, leaving the fragment where it lay for the constable.

On the carpet, the bell's chipped base had a dark mark along one edge. It was an observation, not a laboratory result. No one in the house was equipped to test it. Felix said the bell should be preserved as a possible weapon.

The dispatch box was still locked. A small handwritten slip beside it read: 'The house, the order, the hour. Three answers, one lock.' Edmund had always preferred a puzzle to a label. Tonight that habit had become another obstacle between you and the truth.

CHAPTER 12

The Niece's Debt

Nora admitted that the letter in her bag was from a creditor. She had borrowed money to keep a small theatre company alive. Edmund had refused her first request for help, and she feared he would refuse again.

'He thought I was buying applause,' she said. 'I was paying wages.' Her anger seemed old and tired rather than theatrical.

She had followed Martha upstairs at 9:12. They carried the linen box together, set it outside the damaged room, and inspected the leak. Martha remembered Nora holding the lamp continuously while she climbed a short ladder. They returned downstairs at 9:18.

The account did not make Nora honest about everything. It did place her with another person during the bell at 9:14. A reason to want money was not the same as an opportunity to commit murder.

Nora told you that Edmund had recently spoken of opening the collection to local scholars. She had taken this to mean the house would be sold. 'Perhaps I heard what frightened me most,' she said.

You asked to preserve the debt letter with the other records. She handed it over immediately. For the first time that evening, someone offered a secret without first asking what you already knew.

CHAPTER 13

A Doctor at the Telephone

Felix was offended by the suggestion that his movements needed checking. He became less offended when you explained that everyone's movements did.

He had treated Edmund for years. Recently they had disagreed over a letter Felix had written endorsing a dubious charitable clinic. Edmund believed the endorsement careless and intended to withdraw his own support. Felix feared professional embarrassment, not merely the loss of a patient.

The telephone operator could not be reached again, but the household call pad recorded the first connection at 9:09. Martha had written it down before the kitchen leak distracted her. Gideon said he had seen Felix in the alcove at 9:13 and again at 9:16, still arguing with the line.

That did not create an unbroken alibi. The alcove was a short walk from the library. You marked the gaps rather than filling them with assumptions.

Felix had a smooth white shirt beneath his charcoal jacket. There was no pale violet cuff or visible tear. You made no attempt to turn that observation into a general proof of innocence.

'People will prefer a doctor as the villain,' he said. 'It saves them having to understand the rest.' You replied that the rest was precisely what you intended to understand.

CHAPTER 14

The Dealer's Catalogue

Gideon gave you the printed exhibition list and said he had spent the crucial minutes in the gallery and map room. You could confirm part of that account yourself: he had been close enough to comment when the bell sounded.

He admitted negotiating the sale of two drawings from the collection. He believed Edmund had authorized Celia to arrange them. She had supplied letters of authority and provenance notes; Gideon had paid the proceeds into an account she described as the estate's restoration fund.

When you asked whether he had ever spoken to Edmund about the sales, he hesitated. 'An agent is supposed to save the principal's time.'

The catalogue in his hand contained reproductions of the drawings. One description called a replacement photograph an original wash study. Celia had typed the accompanying notes. Gideon pointed to the raised leg on the capital R as if a machine's defect could absolve the person who accepted its words.

He had motive to avoid a scandal. He had also left a paper trail that could be checked. Those facts could coexist.

You kept the catalogue. On its final page, beside the entry for the astronomical drawing, Edmund had pencilled a question: 'If the original is in York, why has London already sold it?'

CHAPTER 15

The Housekeeper's Omission

Martha had worked at Ashcombe House for twenty-nine years. She knew which stair creaked, which guest disliked cloves, and which family quarrels would survive the death of the people who began them.

She first said she had been in the kitchen throughout the early part of the evening. When you mentioned the linen box, she corrected herself. She had wanted to keep Nora's distress out of the account.

'She was crying upstairs,' Martha said. 'Not for long. She asked me whether he could really leave the house away from her.'

Martha confirmed the interval from 9:12 to 9:18. She also confirmed that she had carried the handbell to Edmund at 9:08 and seen Celia return the key at 9:22. She had not watched the pantry continuously in between.

Edmund had told her the house would become a trust, with employment protected for the resident staff. She had no reason to confuse that plan with an immediate sale. Nora, apparently, had not been given the same explanation.

You wrote down Martha's first omission as well as her correction. A witness could be protective and still be useful. The task was to find what each statement actually supported, rather than demand that every person be either wholly reliable or wholly false.

CHAPTER 16

The Groundskeeper's Boots

Arthur had feared the questions since the library door opened. He looked at his muddy boots whenever someone mentioned the service corridor.

At last he admitted taking coal from the estate store for his sister's cottage. Edmund had discovered the shortage. Arthur expected dismissal and had spent supper trying to judge whether the invitation was kindness or a warning.

He had helped the cook and Martha with the leak, then carried a bucket along the service corridor. He heard the bell at 9:14 and the service door close shortly afterwards. He saw no face, no coat, no fleeing figure. When pressed, he repeated the limits of his account.

'If I say I saw someone, you will ask me who. I didn't.'

At 9:17 he reached the kitchen. The cook remembered because she sent him back for a second bucket. His movements left gaps, but his fear explained why he had tried to shorten his story.

On the floor beside the library service door you found water, not a distinctive trail. Half the household had walked through wet passages. You refused to promote an ordinary muddy mark into a unique signature.

Arthur looked relieved when you said so. It was not an acquittal. It was simply one less story built on something the floor could not tell you.

CHAPTER 17

The Archivist's Account

Celia offered the clearest account of all. At 9:10 she borrowed the cupboard key. She delivered the inventory folio, left Edmund alive, and returned directly to the archive. She remained there until you passed at 9:20, then returned the key at 9:22.

You asked whether anyone had seen her leave the library. She said no. You asked how long the delivery had taken. 'Less than a minute.'

The right cuff of her jacket now had an irregular gap beside its triangular repair. She said it had caught on a drawer that afternoon. That answer conflicted with what you remembered from the photograph at 9:05.

You did not show your notes. Instead, you asked about the drawings. She spoke of conservation, temporary substitutions and instructions given verbally. When you mentioned Gideon's restoration account, she said accounts were outside her duties.

But the documents Gideon produced bore her covering letters. The office typewriter, she explained, was shared by anyone who needed it. That was true enough: a machine's unusual R identified a machine, not automatically its operator.

For the first time, the clarity of her statement seemed less reassuring. Every uncertainty had been placed just outside the reach of a witness, while every reassuring detail had been offered with a precise time.

CHAPTER 18

The Room Above the Rain

Martha gave you permission to examine the archive's public work area while Celia remained in the gallery with the others. You made an inventory before moving any papers and kept the sequence of folders intact.

The typewriter carried a sheet of exhibition labels. Its capital R matched the raised leg in the provenance notes. That linked the documents to a common machine. It did not settle who had typed them.

Inside an open correspondence tray lay a reply from the York conservation workshop. The workshop had declined an enquiry about the astronomical drawing six weeks earlier. It had never received the original. The date contradicted Celia's explanation in the map room.

You also found a carbon-copy remittance advice addressed to 'C. Ward, private commission account'. The amount matched the seller's payment in Gideon's sales statement. The phrase 'restoration fund' did not appear anywhere on it.

These were stronger facts than the typewriter defect. A false explanation, an account in a named person's control, and a sale represented as an authorized estate transaction formed a pattern that could be investigated.

You placed the records in separate sleeves. Outside, rain struck the high archive window with the hard, repeated sound of someone asking to be let in.

CHAPTER 19

What the Photograph Could Say

Arthur developed the gallery plate in the small darkroom used for cataloguing objects. You stayed with him and recorded the plate holder's label, G-17, so there would be no confusion about which exposure you were examining.

The image was imperfect at the edges, but Celia's right cuff was sharp. The pale fabric was complete at 9:05. Its triangular repair and double stitching were visible above her wrist.

You compared that image with a sketch of the cuff as it appeared at 9:20. A triangular piece was now missing beside the repair. The visible fragment in Edmund's hand appeared to have the same colour and two lines of stitching. A careful physical comparison would be needed when the constable arrived.

The photograph could not name a murderer. It could disprove a specific claim: the cuff had not been torn that afternoon. The damage had occurred sometime between 9:05 and 9:20.

That interval included Celia's errand to the library, the bell at 9:14 and the stretch of time during which her only alibi was her own statement.

You wrote the conclusion in exactly those terms. Evidence was most useful when it was allowed to say enough, without being forced to say everything.

CHAPTER 20

The House, the Order, the Hour

The dispatch box carried a three-wheel combination lock. Edmund's slip offered three answers: the house, the order, the hour. Beneath the words he had drawn a tiny open book.

Martha found the estate visitor booklet in the hall. Edmund had written a short verse on its last page, then marked a note about arranging four archive labels. A final note explained that the hour must come from the corrected appointment, not the grand announcement.

This was not an elaborate security system. Edmund liked leaving small puzzles for Nora when she visited, and the household knew his habits. He had apparently reused one now because he did not want the box opened casually before the meeting.

You copied the three tasks rather than attempting the lock by trial and error. A correct answer would tell you where to look next. An incorrect answer would mean returning to the instructions and checking the reasoning.

Meanwhile, the others waited. Gideon asked whether the box might contain the will. Nora asked whether it contained a letter. Celia asked whether the police should open it instead.

You decided to record its condition and solve the instructions with witnesses present. Nothing would be removed or destroyed. If Edmund had prepared an account of the evening, everyone deserved to know what it actually said.

CHAPTER 21

The Missing Announcement

On the desk, beneath a blotter, you found a draft of Edmund's announcement. It named a charitable trust that would preserve the house and collection for public study. Staff posts would continue. Nora would receive a private allowance, but no authority to sell the collection.

The draft explained several fears and several mistakes. Nora had believed she would lose her home without support. Martha knew more of the employment arrangements. Gideon had assumed the collection might be dispersed. None of those assumptions was the whole plan.

At the bottom Edmund had added: 'Before signature, the inventory must be corrected and the unauthorized transfers reported.' He had underlined 'before'.

The announcement was not simply about inheritance. It was about moving the collection into a structure where its contents and accounts would be examined independently. Someone who had relied on informal authority would soon have to explain formal records.

You showed the draft to the group. Celia read it twice. Gideon began to speak, then stopped when Nora asked him what he had bought.

The house seemed smaller now. Its secrets were no longer spread across generations. They were converging on a few dates, a few payments, and the last private conversation Edmund had expected to finish before half past nine.

CHAPTER 22

Two Doors, One Account

You walked the route from the library service door to the archive with Martha. At an ordinary pace it took less than a minute. The passage bent beside the pantry, which explained why Arthur could hear the door without seeing who used it.

There was no secret architecture to discover. No panel moved. No bell rope led elsewhere. The ordinary route was enough to allow someone to leave the library after 9:14 and be seated in the archive when you passed at 9:20.

That established possibility, not identity. Arthur knew the passage; Martha used it daily. Several others could have found it. You marked it on a simple plan and returned to the evidence that distinguished one person from another.

The key book proved Celia borrowed the cupboard key at 9:10. Her own account admitted visiting Edmund. The photograph contradicted her explanation of the torn cuff. The financial records contradicted her explanation of the absent drawings.

No single clock trick was needed. No impossible locked room needed to be explained. The difficulty was quieter: a person had told a plausible story during a stretch of time when nobody could check it.

You asked each guest to write one correction to their earlier statement. Most found something to change. Celia wrote that she had no corrections.

CHAPTER 23

The Last Questions

Before accusing anyone, you made three columns in your notebook: motive, opportunity and physical connection. Each suspect belonged in at least one column. Only a supported account joining all three would justify a conclusion.

You placed Nora's debt beside Martha's corroborated upstairs interval. You placed Felix's professional quarrel beside the gaps in the telephone evidence. You placed Gideon's questionable purchases beside your own sight of him in the gallery when the bell rang.

Arthur's coal theft explained his fear, but not the cloth. Martha's omission protected Nora, but her revised account could be tested. Celia's explanations required the photograph to be misleading, the payment to be innocent, and an unwitnessed return to the archive to be accepted as fact.

Those were questions, not yet a verdict. You needed the contents of the dispatch box, a proper comparison of the fragment, and a reconstruction that did not invent actions nobody had reason to perform.

Outside, someone shouted from the drive. The constable and a second man had crossed the shallowest part of the lane on foot. Martha went to let them in.

You closed your notebook. Soon someone would ask for an answer. The difference between suspicion and an accusation would lie in how carefully you could explain the path from one to the other.

CHAPTER 24

Before the Final Bell

The constable took charge of the library, recorded the position of the bell and preserved the cloth fragment. He asked you to remain available, along with everyone who had heard the sound at 9:14.

You handed him your notes in time order. Where you had witnessed something yourself, you said so. Where you relied on another person's account, you named them. Where a time was approximate, you left it approximate.

The house no longer seemed theatrical. A frightened niece sat beside a housekeeper who had tried to protect her. A doctor waited to defend his judgement. A dealer rehearsed explanations that would not improve with repetition. A groundskeeper held his borrowed tie between both hands. An archivist watched the papers.

Edmund's dispatch box stood in the centre of the gallery table. The combination tasks lay beside it, ready to be solved. His final record would not replace the other evidence; it would have to be read against it.

The gallery clock moved towards ten. You thought of the invitation's final sentence: a witness with no interest in the outcome. That had never meant a witness without responsibility.

Now decide what the evidence supports. Open the appropriate packets, test the contradictions, and write your accusation before consulting the separate Solution Guide. The last bell of Ashcombe House has sounded. The next words belong to you.

CAST & RECOLLECTION

The six people who stayed



Celia Ward

Archivist, 36



Nora Ashcombe

Niece, 27



Dr Felix Mercer

Family doctor, 49



Gideon Pike

Art and manuscript dealer, 44



Martha Reed

Housekeeper, 57



Arthur Bell

Groundskeeper, 41

NEXT STEPS

Your investigation begins

You have reached the end of the narrative, not the end of the case. Separate observation from interpretation. A lie may conceal a debt, a theft, a professional embarrassment or the killing itself.

Read the Character Cards as shared dossiers. Read E01-E08 and E10-E12 in the Clues & Evidence PDF. Keep E09 covered or unprinted until the combination has been checked. No internet research or specialist forensic knowledge is required.

Solve P1-P3 to unlock E09, then use P4-P6 to organize your reasoning and submit one final accusation. The time printed on the lock-check strip is not a clue. All case times use the same household clock and the normal 12-hour evening notation.

THREE QUESTIONS

Who caused Edmund Ashcombe's death? Why? Which independent pieces of evidence connect that person to the event, rather than merely to a secret?

First observations